

After מלאך calls אברהם אבינו on the מזבח, placing יצחק אבינו on the עקדה, The תורה tells us that the מלאך called אברהם twice. The first time, it says (22:12) *וַיֹּאמֶר אֵל תְּשַׁלַּח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנֶּעֱר וְאֵל תַּעֲשֶׂה לוֹ מְאוּמָה כִּי יֵרָא אֱלֹקִים אֵתָּה וְלֹא תִשָּׁכֶת אֶת בְּנֶךָ אֶת יְחִידְךָ מִמֶּנִּי*. The מלאך tells him: “Don’t harm him, because now I know that you are ירא אלקים, for you did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי.”

Then, the מלאך calls out to אברהם a second time (22:15-17):

*וַיֹּאמֶר מְלָאֲךָ ה' אֵל אֲבִרָהָם שְׁנִית מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם: וַיֹּאמֶר בִּי נִשְׁבַּעְתִּי נָאָם ה' כִּי יַעַן אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתָ אֶת הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה וְלֹא תִשָּׁכֶת אֶת בְּנֶךָ אֶת יְחִידְךָ: כִּי בְרַח אֲבִרָכְךָ וְהִרְבָּה אֲרֻכָּה אֶת יָרְעֶךָ*

The Vilna Gaon points out that there’s a massive difference between the first calling of the מלאך to אברהם and the second. In the first the מלאך says, “You did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי - from me.” Who is speaking here? The מלאך is speaking. But in the second ברכה, it says it is given *in the name of ה'.*

The גר"א asks a phenomenal קשיא: Why would the מלאך say מִמֶּנִּי, from me? Was אברהם offering יצחק to the מלאך? Certainly not. How could the מלאך say, “You did not withhold your son from me”?

The גר"א provides an answer that almost only the גר"א could say. We know that every time a person does a מצוה, it creates a מלאך, and the quality of that מלאך corresponds to the quality of the מצוה itself. What qualities contribute to a מצוה? אהבה, זריזות, יראה, כוונה - these aspects and others influence the quality of the מלאך created by the מצוה.

So who is speaking to אברהם אבינו now? The מלאך that was created through the מצוה of the עקדה. It is this מלאך who says, “Now I know that you are ירא אלקים, for you did not withhold your son מִמֶּנִּי - from me.” The מלאך is effectively saying, “Look at the level I represent; from my high מדרגה, you can see the greatness of the שמים of אברהם אבינו יראת ה'.” How do you know that I know? מִמֶּנִּי - from me”. The quality of the מלאך created by the עקדה reflects the greatness of this מצוה.

This teaches us a profound מוסר. When we do מצוה, we should invest in them to elevate their quality. The מדרגה of our מצוה reflects the greatness of our achievements. If we put more כוונה, more time, more אהבה and יראת ה', it translates into a greater מצוה. Whether or not our מצוה create a מלאך is not the main point - although if the מדרש says so, we believe it. The lesson is about the quality of our מצוה. Our מצוה should express our deep כוונה, our אהבה and יראת ה', and that way, they will be of the highest quality. In the זכות of those מצוה, may הקדוש ברוך הוא grant us גאון, נחמדות, and ביאת צדק במהרה בימינו אמן!

